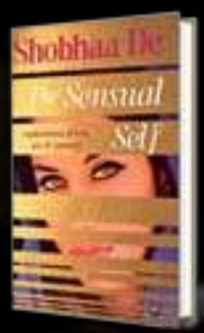
# RECLAIMING ROMANCE

*In her latest book,* The Sensual Self, **Shobhaa Dé** *dives deep into love, desire and intimacy with trademark honesty*

*Photograph by* **MANDAR DEODHAR**




**THE SENSUAL SELF:** Explorations of Love, Sex & Romance
*By Shobhaa Dé*
ALEPH BOOK COMPANY
₹**599; 232** pages

**Q. In your new book, you say women shouldn't settle for routine 'dal-chawal' sex and men need to "put in more effort". What keeps so many people—especially women—hesitant about exploring their desires?**

A woman risks losing her partner if she articulates her sexual needs, or voices disappointment in bed. Men definitely need to wake up and smell the ittar.

**Q. Has India become more open about discussing sex, or are we still trapped in hypocrisy and double standards?**

There has been a radical change in India. Sex is no longer a dirty word. Conversations around it are far more candid. But double standards and hypocrisy still exist. 'Dudes' can enjoy sex anywhere, anytime, with anyone. No questions asked. That's not so with young girls who want the same freedom.

**Q. Today's landscape of love is crowded with 'situationships' that blur traditional notions of commitment. How do you see people—especially women—navigating this new vocabulary of intimacy?**

Women need to learn a thing or two about sensuality from their naanis and daadis. The new vocabulary is a bit too businesslike, stripped of magic, uncertainty and romance. Banking over bonking is the new mood-board out there.

**Q. You've always written with remarkable candour about subjects many tiptoe around. Was *The Sensual Self* a more personal reckoning with your own sensuality?**

It was one of the toughest books I have written. The personal perspective was essential since it spoke about universal truths, but in a real, felt way. I wanted readers to identify with the sensual experiences narrated.

*—with* ***Amit Dixit***